

The Vietnamese communist movement, headed by Nguyen Ai Quoc, later known as Ho Chi Minh, was also based in China until the Chinese Kuomintang government turned against the communists in 1927. Three years later, Ho founded the Indochinese Communist Party in Hong Kong, then a British colony. The party patiently extended its clandestine influence among Vietnamese workers and peasants, but it was a small movement, in no position to challenge the French regime.

World War II transformed the situation in Vietnam. The German occupation of France in June 1940 shattered French prestige and left French Indochina exposed to pressure from Japan, which had been fighting a war in China since 1937. In September 1940, Japanese troops invaded French Indochina, the Japanese effecting a military occupation of Vietnam that was barely resisted by France.



New occupants

During World War II, the Japanese sent troops into Indochina—like these men, carrying Japan’s “Rising Sun” flag. The occupying forces left Vietnam’s colonial system in place, including its army and police.

Nationalist strategy

The humiliation of the French, and of other Europeans in Asia at this time, encouraged Vietnamese nationalism. It also raised the possibility of new support. By offering to attack the Japanese in Indochina, nationalists could pitch for the backing of the Allies at war with Japan, including Kuomintang China and the United States.

In 1941, in a remote area on the border with southern China, Ho Chi Minh and his communist colleagues founded the Viet Minh Doc Lap Dong Minh (League for the Independence of Vietnam), shortened to Viet Minh. Their intention was to create a broad-based nationalist movement that would attract support from all strata of Vietnamese society. Their declared objectives were the defeat of the “fascist Japanese” and their